Ariana Grande Leads a Starry Christmas Carol on TV

From: Billboard Mined: 2026-11-09 3 min read

It is beginning to sound a lot like Christmas on late-night TV. Pop star Ariana Grande teamed up with Robert De Niro and Ben Stiller for a surprise Christmas **carol** on The Tonight Show on Sunday night. The **trio** sang the traditional tune 'O Christmas Tree' to ring in the holiday season. Grande took the lead on **vocals**, and the audience applauded when she hit those high notes. Stiller gave a **valiant** effort on his part of the song. As for De Niro, you will have to watch the clip to see how his turn plays out. The performance celebrated the arrival of the 2026 Rockefeller Center Christmas tree this weekend. The episode aired at 11:35 p.m. ET, right after a football game, and featured rapper Lil Baby as the musical guest. The stars were on the show to promote their new movie, Focker-in-Law, which opens in **theatres** on November 25. It is the latest film in the popular Meet the Parents series. Grande plays Olivia Jones, who is dating Henry, the grown-up son of Greg and Pam Focker.

Word Treasure

carol -- A song people sing at Christmas time.
valiant -- Brave and trying hard, even when something is difficult.
trio -- A group of three people, often singers or musicians.
vocals -- The singing part of a song.
theatres -- Places where people go to watch films on a big screen.

Background you need

A Christmas carol is a song people sing at Christmas time.

A late-night talk show is a TV show that comes on late at night, with a host who chats with famous guests.

The Rockefeller Center Christmas tree is a huge tree put up in New York City every year.

Break it down

WHO: Ariana Grande, Robert De Niro, Ben Stiller and host Jimmy Fallon.
WHAT: The three stars sang a surprise Christmas carol on TV.
WHERE: On The Tonight Show, on late-night TV.
WHY: To celebrate the arrival of the Rockefeller Center Christmas tree and their new movie.

Why it matters

If you love singing Christmas songs with your family, this story shows how even famous stars enjoy sharing a carol together.

Test what you remember

1. Who sang 'O Christmas Tree'?

(A) Sylvester Stallone and Luke Bryan
(B) Ariana Grande, Robert De Niro and Ben Stiller
(C) Jennifer Lopez and Anthony Mackie
(D) Jimmy Fallon and Lil Baby

2. On which show did they perform?

(A) The Voice
(B) Saturday Night Live
(C) The Tonight Show
(D) Sunday Night Football

3. What was the performance celebrating?

(A) A new album
(B) The start of the football season
(C) The arrival of the Rockefeller Center Christmas tree
(D) The end of the year

4. When does Focker-in-Law open in theatres?

(A) September 27
(B) November 25
(C) January 10
(D) November 15

5. Who does Grande play in the movie?

(A) Teri Polo
(B) Pam Focker
(C) Olivia Jones
(D) Henry

6. What time did the episode air?

(A) 11:35 p.m. ET
(B) 12:00 p.m. ET
(C) 8:00 p.m. ET
(D) 9:00 a.m. ET

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: C 4: B 5: C 6: A

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):